Yuxi Zhong (Sonam Dorji)
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EDUCATION

Northeastern University, Shenyang, China 09/2022 – 06/2025
M.A. in *Art Theory* GPA: 3.90/4.0

Sichuan Agricultural University, Chengdu, China 09/2018 – 06/2022
B.A. in *Politics and Public Administration* GPA: 3.57/4.0

PUBLICATIONS AND PRESENTATION

Journal Articles

- Zhong, Yuxi. "When a Cat Becomes a God" (revised and resubmitted following major and minor revisions)
- Zhong, Yuxi, and Zhang Yannan. 2023. "The Aesthetic Connotation of the Word '乐' and Its Direction Towards Aesthetic Development." *China National Exhibition* 24, 232-234. [In Chinese]

Conference Paper

Zhong, Yuxi. "The Death of the Rat: Memory and Identity of Cat-Worship Culture in Xiangcheng." "Mountains and Seas" Ethnology Graduate Student Forum, April 26-27, 2025.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Clay Sculpture Apprenticeship and Ethnographic Fieldwork in Xiangcheng
Independent Researcher and Craft Apprentice 05/2026 – 10/2026

- Apprenticed with a local clay artisan who makes sculptures for household shrine rooms and stove walls. Assisted with preparation, hand-modeling, crack repair, painting, and spraying, while learning about the materials and techniques involved in their construction.
- Lived with a local household and studied how people learn and pass on the knowledge that goes into making and caring for these figures: how to read the clay, where a figure belongs, and when to mend or replace it. Kept over 80,000 Chinese characters of field notes and documented the making process in photographs and video.

The Dialogue between "Om" and "Xiang": Art, Memory, and Identity in Xiangcheng Stove Cults
M.A. Thesis, Independent Researcher 10/2023 – 06/2025

- Designed and executed a nine-month ethnographic fieldwork study, employing participant observation, in-depth interviews (n=100+), and visual/material analysis (700+ photographs), supplemented by survey analysis in SPSS and qualitative coding in NVivo.
- Traced the gradual remaking of the Buddhist figure Nehulay as the Stove Cat through changes in visual form, naming, craft practice, and household care. Framed this process

as a "vernacular religious ecology," in which sacred presence is made and sustained through local materials and everyday domestic practice.

Grassroots Governance and Community Dynamics in Urban China

Core Research Team Member 11/2019 – 02/2021

- Designed and executed a mixed-methods study on community governance across 7 award-winning urban communities in Chengdu. Employed quantitative (136 completed questionnaires) and qualitative (50+ structured interviews) approaches to analyze the mechanisms of resident participation and service delivery.
- Developed a "One Core, Two Networks, Three Guarantees" governance framework, which was later adopted by three communities to guide their policy and practice. Formed the basis of my B.A. thesis on resident participation.

Visual Culture and Material Memory in Chinese Revolutionary Heritage Sites

Core Research Team Member 11/2018 – 06/2019

- Contributed to a larger two-year mixed-methods study on revolutionary heritage in the Sichuan-Shaanxi region, analyzing the visual and material strategies of public memorialization through comparative analysis, extensive interviews, and surveys across three cities (N=182, analyzed with SPSS).
- Co-authored a comprehensive research report with policy recommendations, which was officially adopted by three county-level cultural and tourism bureaus.

RESEARCH PROJECTS

Embodied Knowledge and Cultural Transmission in Traditional Puppetry

Participant-Researcher 06/2023 – 09/2023

Conducted three months of participant observation while training and performing with a local troupe. Examined how embodied, non-textual knowledge is transmitted through rehearsal and performance, and how troupe participation sustains community ties.

Ecologies of Heritage: Cultural Revitalization in Rural China

Team Leader 11/2022 – 10/2023

Conducted fieldwork on Bashao Island's customs and intangible cultural heritage, examining links between community life and the local cultural ecosystem. Proposed recommendations for cultural preservation and revitalization.

From Ritual Governance to Aesthetic Transcendence: A Semiotic Study of "乐"

Independent Researcher 11/2022 – 03/2023

Conducted a diachronic semiotic analysis of the polyphonic character "Lè/Yuè" (乐), tracing its changing meanings across three related dimensions: ritual-political order, embodied affect, and cosmological thought. Drawing on historical aesthetics and textual analysis, argued that the distinction between Yuè and Lè reflects changing relations between collective ritual order, embodied aesthetic experience, and ideas of transcendence.

Motifs of Change: Material Culture and Economy in Tibetan Rug Production

Team Leader 06/2020 – 08/2020

- Led a fieldwork team combining one month of fieldwork, artisan surveys, and quantitative analysis of motif frequencies to examine the material, economic, and social meanings of animal imagery in Tibetan rug production; produced a report of more than 10,000 words.

OTHER EXPERIENCE

Research Assistant, Prof. Yannan Zhang, *NEU* 06/2025 – 03/2026
Analyzed survey data (N > 500) in SPSS, assisted with 30+ interviews and experiments, managed a Zotero library of 700+ sources, and prepared literature reviews.

Animal Protection Advocacy and Leadership 09/2018 – Present
Led rehabilitation and rehoming initiatives for 300+ animals, managed the association's public outreach, and organized 21 advocacy events. Represented Southwest China at the Beijing Animal Protection Training Camp.

Peking Opera Study and Performance 09/2018 – 06/2022
Trained in Peking Opera performance and aesthetics; staged three shows and competed in a national collegiate opera competition.

SELECTED HONORS AND AWARDS

Outstanding Graduation Dissertation, *Liaoning Province* 2026
China Int'l College Students' Innovation Comp – *National Bronze* 2024
Second-class Academic Scholarship, *NEU* 2023
Outstanding Individual in Social Practice, *NEU* 2023
China Int'l College Students' Innovation Comp – *Provincial Gold* 2023
First-class Academic Scholarship, *NEU* 2022, 2023
Rank 1st in the Graduate Entrance Examination (Written & Interview) 2022
Outstanding President of the University Association, *SICAU* 2020
Outstanding Individual in Social Research, *SICAU* 2019, 2020, 2021
"Challenge Cup" Natl. College Students' Entrepreneurship Comp. – *Provincial Bronze* 2019

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIP

Member, China Society for Anthropology of Arts 04/2024 – Present

SKILLS

Research Tools | NVivo, SPSS, Zotero, VOSviewer, Adobe (PS, LR, PR), Shapr3D
Languages | Mandarin (Native), Southwestern Mandarin (Native), English (Fluent), Xiangcheng Tibetan (Fluent), Classical Chinese (Proficient in reading)